

La Hauteur

A PLAY BY
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ROLES

Alexis, Hereditary Duke, honorable but angry
Alexis' Father, Duke of Faubremont, megalomaniac
Alexis' Mother, Duchess of Faubremont, infatuated but understanding
Eufemia, lady-in-waiting to the duchess, a dreamer but a damsel
Jean, hereditary chancellor, jester and likes to pull tricks
Teresa, hereditary viscountess, tomboy and foolish
Timéo, a valet, serious and curious
Dieudonné, the Duke's second son, treacherous and strategizing
Henrique, a chamberlain, a liar and kind of fruity
Vespasian, a valet, deadpan and just wants peace
Marceau, an esquire, boastful but a man of his words
Marshal Poitier, man of justice but an idiot
Captain, kind of sexist
Guards

Time: circa 1815

Place: Marseille

PROLOGUE

It is a clear night, a crescent moon dimly lights the ambience of the harbor. The Captain of the trusty cargo ship "Valletta" is sneaking sips from one of the dozen wine barrels onboard. Eufemia, a young and alluring court maiden to the duchess of Faubremont, is working her hands dry. She is on the verge of losing it, she can't take this work for much longer. She is betrothed to Alexis, the son of the domain's Duke, heir to the Duchy of Faubremont. Once she marries Alexis in two weeks, she won't have to put up with her lowly work.

Eufemia is lost in thought, she stays still and puts her work to rest, staring at her scrubbing cloth. The Captain notices her disobedience and rises from next to his beloved wine barrel, tumbling towards the maid shaking his cup through the air.

CAPTAIN

Scrub the latrine, maid!

(stretches his hand towards Eufemia)

EUFEMIA

(slaps his hand away)

Never!

Get off my case, you disgust me

Get off this ship, you depress me

I must leave, hello sleep tight

You'll disappear, and so will I

Comatose in a sleepless city

Fill my eyes with stars and lies

Who will steal me away, I don't know,

Only that I must leave soon

I won't clean it!

I won't!

(She stomps her leg)

CAPTAIN

Away you whore! you can suck it

I'll make you clean with your tongue

So you can taste your own words

(Eufemia protests: how dare you!)

Don't take my words

Keep your own filth

You have lost my interest,

Now begone

(Eufemia runs aboard the ship, down the gangway, and through the streets of Marseille.)

EUFEMIA

(spinning around in her dress with joy)

I'm finally free!

What joy, what will I see?

Not a silhouette?

Oh, is it a man?
I sense danger, this isn't so great

(Duke Gamm enters the scene. He is fairly drunk, but not tumbling. Eufemia tries to hide behind a lamppost, but the Duke already saw her from the other end of the street. He approaches her and gets closer.)

DUKE
What a beauty!
So endearing and fair
Eufemia, you're here my sweetheart?
Why aren't you with Alexis?
A chivalrous husband-to-be
Come closer, I'm a gentleman
And a wonderful lover as well

EUFEMIA
How shameless-

DUKE
Shame is just the fear of lust
I'm not afraid to caress you
(He grabs Eufemia's wrist)

EUFEMIA
I am promised to your son!

(He kisses her, she resists. He won't stop and strips her.)

EUFEMIA
You drunken devil!
Someone, help!
(She turns her head away from him. Instead, he kisses her neck.)
Oh please, you can't!
I beg you!

DUKE
Help, you ask?
So sorry dear
These guards in town, they work for me
Now, be kind to me, darling?
I promise, I'll be even kinder

(Duke Gamm violates Eufemia, her cries call through the empty streets. Two guards patrol the crossing street, noticing the scene that is unfolding. They merely grin and go about their ending day.)

ACT 1: SCENE 1

(The inner chambers of the Chateau de Faubremont. Hereditary Duke Alexis storms through the hall in front of the bath, where the Duke goes about his daily business. As Alexis hears a splash, he busts through the bathroom door, exposing his father.)

ALEXIS

Father! Someone pleased my girl!
And that all without consent
I must find him and get revenge!
This hate in me,
I don't know how long
I can keep it contained
Oh I fear I might break soon
Father! I need your advice

DUKE

(Flustered.)
Alexis, this is the restroom!
Just get out now, I'm not done

ALEXIS

What is that?
(points down to the Duke's pants.)

DUKE

What is what?

ALEXIS

That cloth in your pocket!

DUKE

Begone!

ALEXIS

I have seen it before!

DUKE

Of course!

ALEXIS

It is Eufemia's!
(He is taken aback and moves two steps away.)

DUKE

Understand please!

ALEXIS

Understand what?

(takes out a Dagger from his chest pocket and threatens the Duke.)

Violence is just a way of fear

It's succumbing to instincts

You, too, have fallen,

Lost to temptation

I truly am your son,

And will show you how afraid I am

(He punches the Duke. The Duke falls forward, off the toilet. Alexis hesitates, looking at the dagger in his right hand.)

ALEXIS

Why do I hesitate?

Am I too scared of fear?

Is my hate for immorality

Stopping me from getting revenge?

What good is a son like this

Am I a worthy fiancé?

But taking lives is not my power

My strength lies in reason

I will listen to yours

This next time you awake

(Alexis flees the scene and drops the dagger to the ground. The duke is trying to grasp the air with his trembling hand.)

DUKE

My son punched me in the head

But all is well I am not dead

Betrayed my faith,

But so have I

Well call it even

Where is he?

(Enter Dieudonné. He sees the Duke lying on the floor, desperately trying to rise up from the ground.)

DIEUDONNÉ

The Duke is there,

The Duke's right there!

Oh my what could have happened here?

The son must have struck

The Duke survived through luck-

Or so he might think

The Duke's right there,

But for how long?

If he was gone

I'd have the throne

Kill him right here;
His heart, my spear
Then kill his heir
I'd reign supreme!
The dead won't care

(Dieudonné picks up the dagger from next to the Duke's side and proceeds to ram it into the Duke's chest. The Duke lets out a staggered breath, then breathes no more. Dieudonné keeps the dagger with him, then leaves the scene.)

ACT 1: SCENE 2

(The Chateau's lower chambers. Jean and Teresa enter and have an argument.)

JEAN
So if I touched you in my sleep
That was just an act of god
I swear I do respect you

(Jean gets closer and strokes her cheek with his thumb. She raises her arm and removes his hand from her)

TERESA
Tell that to these breasts you fondled
(turns away)
Now they're red and sore
(holds her chest)
I can't believe I adore a brute

JEAN
But you do, my dear
And that is all that matters
And my touch is just my love language
(Holds her again and won't let go of her)

TERESA
Don't you dare try to
Undress me with your tongue
Keep that one in your mouth
For my lips haven't forgotten yours
Since the last time that you kissed them

(Teresa surrenders to Jean's arms, holding his cheek with her hand)

JEAN
Do my feelings reach you?

TERESA

If one day I fail to love you
I will force my heart to stop

JEAN

That would be the end of me

TERESA

You think this endearingly of me?

JEAN

I don't think about you
I just keep you in my mind
And when we grow old
For each memory you lose
I'll remember for eternity

TERESA

My forever with you has already started
For all my life
My heart won't stop
So for this fleeting eternity
It will carry your name

JEAN

Of course you will carry
My last name after our marriage

TERESA

Oh how I can't wait
Already mine
But I want god to see

JEAN

God doesn't need to
The only eyes meant for you are mine

TERESA

But tell me, does your nose still work?
This odor, ever since we stood here

(Enter Alexis. He must visit the toilet and cannot control himself.)

ALEXIS

Oh my! It feels horrid!
I'm tearing apart!
My body is rotting
I don't feel alive!
The guilt is torturing my stomach

I must find a toilet!
It isn't too far!
But what is this smell? Oh god!

(Holds his nose closed. He finds the toilet completely clogged. Enter Timéo.)

JEAN
What happened?

TIMÉO
What is this?

TERESA
It's covered in brown!

JEAN
Who did this?

TIMÉO
Was it you?
(to Alexis)

TERESA
Alexis how could you?

ALEXIS
Don't insult me, my friends
I'm as clueless as you
We must find who did this
And another restroom too!

JEAN
You still need to shit?

TIMÉO
(raises finger)
That proves his innocence!

TERESA
That's true!

JEAN
Or maybe!

TIMÉO
There's a chance!

TERESA
He just refilled for round two!

ALEXIS

Please, dear friends
 No more of this
 I must find out who it was
 Let's investigate!
 Is there anyone else?
 Just a hint or a clue?
 Let us find suspects
 And use questions for truth!

JEAN

I agree!

TIMÉO

So do I

TERESA

Let's get going!

(Timéo, Jean and Teresa leave. Alexis ponders to himself)

ALEXIS

How could this be?
 Father's death, was it me?
 I may have grabbed the knife
 I swear, I never stabbed
 I spared his life
 Was it someone else?
 Who came and struck
 Oh father, out of luck
 Had I known, I'd have bid farewell
 And I won't come to visit you in hell

(Alexis leaves. Enter Marceau and Vespasian. Marceau sings to Vespasian.)

MARCEAU

My friend! My friend!
 You know I fucked your Wife?
 My Friend, my friend
 Best sex of my whole Life
 My friend, I placed myself inside
 I spent all night
 To copulate with your sweet bride
 And friend, dear Friend
 I also fucked your mum
 My friend, best friend
 She was drowning in my cum
 My friend, I came inside her bum

Had lots of fun
While I was in your mother's plum

VESPASIAN
Why are you doing this to me, man?

MARCEAU
I can't believe my ears!
You talk just like a peasant
You are driving me to tears

VESPASIAN
Just leave my family alone

MARCEAU
So what would you do?
You fool!
I'll get your daughter too!

VESPASIAN
Don't have one

MARCEAU
I just made one for you!

VESPASIAN
Gross, dude

(Vespasian is unamused and leaves. Now Henrique enters, holding his stomach.)

HENRIQUE
It's worse than I thought!
My bowels, how awful!
But what's done is done
What I must do now is hide
And avoid being caught
Those fools, they won't find me
I'll hide in their face
All I must do is convince the Duke

(Dieudonné enters, rumbling to himself about his crime.)

DIEUDONNÉ
I'm lucky
The whole castle drowned in a stench!
The corpse's smell is overshadowed
My problem is that ruck!
My way to the duchy is overcoming that trench
Once my dear brother is alone I'll treat him like cattle!

(Dieudonné approaches Henrique)

DIEUDONNÉ

Hello, good eve, how dost thou fare?
 My best man, are you doing well?
(grabs Henrique's shoulder)
 I'm callous but for you I care
 But answer me, what is that smell?

HENRIQUE

Oh Dieudonné, what am I to do?
 I'm suffering and in pain
 My insides left me for the loo,
 So much to my disdain

DIEUDONNÉ

You live a life in agony
 But deep down you are pure
 Eat macaroons from Euphemia
 I heard they are the cure

HENRIQUE

But listen to me when I say
 Your answer has its flaws
 From cure they are so far away
 For that they are the cause

DIEUDONNÉ

Is that a lie?

HENRIQUE

Oh no, it's true

DIEUDONNÉ

You won't deny?

HENRIQUE

I'd never do
 If you'd excuse me
(steps away)
 My bathroom visit's overdue

DIEUDONNÉ

You've ruined every shitter here,
 But I know just the place
 The girl who did this to you is there,
 Let's ruin her bathroom instead
 I want to see the look on her face

(Dieudonné and Henrique leave. The four heroes Alexis, Jean, Teresa and Timéo return and show Marshal Poitier what has happened.)

ALEXIS

O Marshal lay your eyes
Upon the ravaged toilet bowl
It seems so inhumane
Just who could be so cold

POITIER

My eyes they burn,
My nostrils too
It makes my stomach churn!
Was it one of you?

JEAN

Insulting

TERESA

Not in my nightmares

TIMÉO

I'd never stoop so low

ALEXIS

The culprit can't be far from here

POITIER

Let's search! We all must go

ALEXIS

A moment
You miss one thing,
And that is a suspect
Before we delve into the matter
Let us find some clues

JEAN

It's late

TERESA

It's dark

TIMÉO

And hypnos is taking me hostage

POITIER

The near dawn is when we depart

ALEXIS

Let's start right this spot
When the Time has come

(Everyone leaves the scene.)

ACT 1: SCENE 3

(Later that night, right as everyone else is sleeping. Timéo returns to the scene of the murder, searching thoroughly.)

TIMÉO

I know I can find it,
There must be a hint
I'll search all I can,
Go closer and squint
That smell!
It's not just shit!
It smells like a grave
It's not far away
Hidden right there
In the dark
It is
Oh!

(Timéo finds the corpse of the Duke.)

My Duke, he was struck
But why did it happen?
I must inform the guards!
I cannot waste Time
I just sensed someone...
It must be the murderer
(He hides behind a curtain)

(Enter Dieudonné and Marceau)

DIEUDONNÉ

As you can see,
This isn't good.
The man is dead,
We'd better get rid of him.
And with "we"
I do mean you.

MARCEAU

I'll prepare a bag at once
And keep this light with me
(Marceau leaves.)

(Dieudonné walks around the corpse, paying close attention to the deceased duke. He starts trying to sneak away the corpse by grabbing its ankles.)

TIMÉO

(comes out of hiding)

This darkness, I cannot trust my eyes!

I feel I am deceived

Who took the dear Duke's life

How dare you lowly thief

Reveal your name and face!

DIEUDONNÉ

You speak wise,

It is unfortunate

But I must say for who

Your demise

Was staying late,

Unfortunate for you

(Enter Marceau. He slowly approaches Timéo, pulls a bag over his head, then Marceau stabs him. Slowly, Timéo dies.)

MARCEAU

You've done it this time

A step too far

Just like that, my childhood friend

Our collection memories

Won't expand

DIEUDONNÉ

I digress, Marceau

The one that's done it was you

MARCEAU

Couldn't it have gone another way?

His life didn't need to end

DIEUDONNÉ

How come you blame me

You're a mere esquire

MARCEAU

Exact, I was following your command

DIEUDONNÉ

Did I say those words?

"Kill your friend?"

You acted without me asking

MARCEAU
 You're my lord
 I'd do anything to save your name

DIEUDONNÉ
 I'm not blaming you
 I admire your coldbloodedness
 But do not place your guilt onto me
 Carry it yourself

MARCEAU
 I'm afraid I must
 But you won't add more weight

DIEUDONNÉ
 Fine, suit yourself
 A slave who disobeys his master
 Were I without mercy
 You'd end up just like this valet

MARCEAU
 Without me to do your dirty work?
 You're the one who's in luck

DIEUDONNÉ
 Out of my sight

MARCEAU
 Sobeit
 Take care of this mess yourself
 And of whoever's coming, too
(the sound of footsteps getting closer)

DIEUDONNÉ
 I'm not panicking
 Someone else's hands
 Are stained after all

(Marceau and Dieudonné leave the scene.)

ACT 2: SCENE 1

(Eufemia enters Alexis' bed chamber, seemingly distraught. She falls around his neck.)

EUFEMIA
 Oh 'Lex!
 It's terrible what happened

Like a storm ravaged
 A sick and twisted perpetrator
 My water closet is in shambles!
 Stained and smeared
 The walls, the mirror
(She is about to faint)

ALEXIS
 It just gets worse
 Crime after crime

(Henrique and Dieudonné stand outside the door. They start eavesdropping.)

ALEXIS
 Now listen, Eufemia
 I will find the man that did this to you
 But another duty calls me.
 I must return to the scene of the royal clogging
 Once that's solved, I am all yours

EUFEMIA
 I'll wait right here

(Alexis leaves. Eufemia lies down on Alexis' bed. Henrique and Dieudonné lean against the wall, the Duke's son fails to see them.)

DIEUDONNÉ
 'Twas a triumph, take a look!
 Her face so pale
 Like a corpse

HENRIQUE
 Indeed, it is a fine prank
 But is this the right way
 to make her give up baking

DIEUDONNÉ
 Afraid not
 Let's take the matter in our hands
 For long as she lives she won't stop

HENRIQUE
 You'd assassinate the maid-in-waiting?
 She's never harmed a fly

DIEUDONNÉ
 Your intestines beg to differ

HENRIQUE

You got me there
Alright, I'll yield

DIEUDONNÉ
This here might come in handy
(*shows Henrique his dagger*)

HENRIQUE
Why is it wrapped in cloth?

DIEUDONNÉ
It's stained with blood

HENRIQUE
Tell me the reason

DIEUDONNÉ
I ended the Duke's life with it

HENRIQUE
You jest, I'm sure

DIEUDONNÉ
Your conviction deceives you
But please, don't despair
I ensure you, there's a goal to my scheme
My brother may be the rightful heir
I deem him unfit however
So obsessed with justice
He would sentence you
So switch to my team?

HENRIQUE
You'd treat my kind well?

DIEUDONNÉ
Nothing else

HENRIQUE
So be it, what's your bright idea?

DIEUDONNÉ
Frame him with this dagger of course
It has his name engraved, as well
And see his bride-to-be right there?
If she was out the picture too
You could have spared that rotten loo
Down with her!
And those macaroons

HENRIQUE

A fair argument
I never fancied that girl
Or any maidens at that
A hunky man
Would satisfy me enough

DIEUDONNÉ

If you spin that way

HENRIQUE

You judge?

DIEUDONNÉ

Never!
My brother, though
He says it odd
Finds the thought repulsive
Sure you see, he's unfit to rule

HENRIQUE

But still, he's your kin
And death is absolute
Would imprisonment be an alternative?
Heard the near gaol has gentle guards

DIEUDONNÉ

Suppose that would suffice
Long as he stays out the picture
Now go about your day

HENRIQUE

I will trap him like a fish
A moment, though
Why don't you take matters into your own hands?

DIEUDONNÉ

I have more important matters

HENRIQUE

Those being

DIEUDONNÉ

The ones trying to escape me

HENRIQUE

You can't mean-

DIEUDONNÉ

I do

I ate them too

Those damned macaroons

(holding his stomach)

That wench shall pay

But now, let's go 'bout our day

HENRIQUE

Farewell

(They both leave. Eufemia quickly rises from the bed at the sound of footsteps, she glances out the door but fails to see someone.)

ACT 2: SCENE 2

(The Duke's bathroom. Alexis, Jean and Teresa enter and find Poitier, with several policemen next to Timéo murdered on the toilet.)

POITIER

'Tis a crime scene, lads

And an ugly one at that

He may have been a squire

But a life is a great loss

ALEXIS

My dearest friend lies there

Murdered on the bathroom floor

I'm delving in despair

He's dead, it's real

I'm shooketh to the core

JEAN

A tragedy

TERESA

Sure it is

POITIER

But who could it have been?

(Henrique enters. He holds his hand to his ear, seemingly having eavesdropped)

HENRIQUE

I know who killed

And shat as well

He stands by the corpse

The man who can't control himself

On the shitter or his rage
I'll tell you!
He clogged the drain
With his butt
Then our dead friend found him sitting
Angered he assaulted him
And then he finished shitting

ALEXIS
You speak in falsehoods
Watch yourself
I feel betrayed
Accuse me but know for sure
You won't get away with this

HENRIQUE
Is that a threat?
Wasn't he enough?
Please spare me murderer
I hope you bluff

POITIER
My god it's worse than I thought
Please check behind this wall
Hidden deep inside a cloth
I couldn't tell a corpse's smell
The lavatory is too foul
Our Duke, our Duke has fallen

JEAN
The Duke?

TERESA
Oh Duke

ALEXIS
My father, too?

HENRIQUE
How could you!

ALEXIS
Spare me these insults!

HENRIQUE
Lock him up!
I'm scared to death
These halls are cursed
Drag away this filthy maniac

(Vespasian and Marceau appear. Marceau defends Alexis.)

MARCEAU

Don't judge too soon
I have my doubts
That Alexis did all this
Been friends all life
I know his worth
Just prove it to the rest?

ALEXIS

I won't just prove my vest is clean
I'll go one step beyond
Trapped shall be
This heinous fiend
And all by my own hand

MARCEAU

How noble, 'Lex

ALEXIS

That's how I am

MARCEAU

Don't need to tell me twice

(Henrique intervenes)

HENRIQUE

All's well that's well
Oh well, so well
Bit biased, this defense?
I'd hear you out
Just wonder how
You'll show your innocence?
You'll capture him?
But when and where?
A villain never sees his flaws

VESPASIAN

Don't run your mouth

HENRIQUE

But he'll run off
Well well
I'll keep still
For now

(Dieudonné enters)

DIEUDONNÉ
I won't

ALEXIS
Brother, what brings you here?

DIEUDONNÉ
Not another word from you
I can't believe the things you'd do
Just to gain some power
Is it difficult to wait?
The throne is already yours to take
But letting a murderer rule?
Don't take these people for a fool

ALEXIS
What are you saying?
You believe Henrique?

DIEUDONNÉ
The wound looks like a dagger's cut
Don't you carry one at all times?
You adore it

ALEXIS
How would you know?
No way did you investigate

DIEUDONNÉ
I gathered intel
I'm soon to be the duke, you see

ALEXIS
You're behind this

DIEUDONNÉ
What a weak rebuttal
You only speculate
If it were after me
They should put you behind bars

ALEXIS
Brother, you infuriate me

DIEUDONNÉ
Lusting for blood again?
How vile

Instead of murders
You should practice elegance
Now, I must depart
(leaves.)

ALEXIS
What is his plan?
I will prove it was him, not me

(Everyone leaves.)

ACT 2: SCENE 3

(Night Time. Alexis, Jean and Teresa enter. Alexis goes to the toilet. Jean and Teresa hide in the bushes nearby.)

JEAN
(to Teresa)
It's gonna stink
What do you think
While we stand beside this man

TERESA
You're right, it's true
The smell of poo
Let's take off while we can!

ALEXIS
You utter fools
I'm not doing anything
It's all just to pretend
Your minds are tricked
And lacking strength
So silence, this is serious

TERESA
(to Jean)
Hey Comrade

JEAN
Aye?

TERESA
Did Alexis just...?

JEAN
Imply that we are fools?

TERESA
Who knows

JEAN
I lack the brain to know

ALEXIS
(to himself)
Why did I bring you two?

JEAN
Can't tell

TERESA
Too dumb for that

ALEXIS
And keeping quiet, too

(They wait for a while but nobody shows up. Alexis' plan failed.)

TERESA
Wait a second
Do you hear it?

JEAN
He wails and weeps
But who?

TERESA
He sounds pathetic

(Timéo's ghost appears. Only Alexis seems to be surprised.)

GHOST TIMÉO
Is this how you greet
Your long lost friend?

TERESA
You're lost
But not that long

ALEXIS
You're not surprised?
Just look! A ghost
It's Timéo!
I can't believe my eyes

TERESA

Well he isn't that scary to be honest

JEAN

Don't break character

TERESA

Apologies, comrade

JEAN

Now tell us, ghost

What brings you here?

Gehenna waits for you

GHOST TIMÉO

Listen closely, friends

My life's been taken

By an evil man

My spirit haunts these stench'd up lands

One thing could help

What won't let me rest

Is this one missing clue

Quite a grave one too

I was stabbed right in the back

My face turned away

So I never saw his

Investigating late at night

I witnessed Dieudonné with the corpse

Then someone else just took my life

Too dark to see, even for me

This culprit stays a mystery

ALEXIS

What a tragedy!

GHOST TIMÉO

Oh yes, wise words

It's up to you now

Set me free

ALEXIS

Or else?

GHOST TIMÉO

You take me for a fool?

JEAN

He does

TERESA
I can relate

ALEXIS
Apologies

GHOST TIMÉO
Let's pay him back
I'll curse you!
Want to lift it?
Find the culprit

ALEXIS
Vile friend you are

GHOST TIMÉO
So what, I'm dead
How would you retaliate?

TERESA
That's logical

ALEXIS
But fiendish

GHOST TIMÉO
Curse curse!
Farewell

(Ghost Timéo leaves. Alexis holds his head.)

ALEXIS
This pain is strange

JEAN
That could be the curse
My advice: just do as he said

ALEXIS
Of course, no other way
It's just
I would have helped him either way
A curse?
Nonsense
A favor was all he should have asked for

(Ghost Timéo returns)

TERESA

You again?

What did you forget?

Please spare us

Alexis curse is enough

GHOST TIMÉO

I have one more thing

A crucial clue

I may know who clogged the drain!

ALEXIS

You do?

GHOST TIMÉO

Most certainly, now listen up

That vassal, Henrique

The night before

He squealed and pushed

His essence out

All because of macaroons

TERESA

But what's your proof?

GHOST TIMÉO

I ate them too

But I went to the gardens

Only he was there

Then he ran upstairs

The rest is all deduction

ALEXIS

Those macaroons

Not Eufemia's, could it be?

GHOST TIMÉO

I don't owe you anymore words

(Ghost Timéo leaves again)

ALEXIS

That idiot

When he does these things,

It makes me glad he's gone

TERESA

Such horrid words!

However, I find myself agreeing

JEAN
My companions
I wonder, are we done?
I doubt the villain will show up now

ALEXIS
This feels off
This shitter, it won't let me leave

TERESA
Jean, look!
There's a silhouette
Quick! Let's hide in these bushes a bit better

(Henrique enters the scene.)

HENRIQUE
So splendid and great
My plan was infallible
Look at the fish that I caught
There's nobody else,
How should I dispose of you?
Gut you and throw you in the sea?
No one shall know 'bout my sins

ALEXIS
You speak of the clogging?

HENRIQUE
Silence, you carp

ALEXIS
I fail to understand your fish reference

HENRIQUE
I see, that's my bad
I thought it was clever

ALEXIS
At first, but you just did too much

HENRIQUE
Who cares about that!
What matters is you're mine
And with you, my secret shall die!

ALEXIS

How low you would fall
I've always admired you
No more, though

HENRIQUE

Keep blabbering,
There's not one thing to do!

(The Marshal enters)

POITIER

Fancy meeting you here, chamberlain
What is the occasion?

HENRIQUE

Perfect timing, Sir
The culprit is trapped.
He returned to the scene of his crimes.
Alexis is in here, he murdered his father
And the valet Timéo as well
And worst of all
He clogged the lavatory

POITIER

How do you prove your claim?

HENRIQUE

See this dagger, with the Duke's blood?
I ripped it from his hands!

ALEXIS

You lie too much!

HENRIQUE

A true duke stands up to his wrongs.
I, however, am a man of my words

ALEXIS

You're a man of turds!

HENRIQUE

(flabbergasted)

You better rinse that filthy mouth
Before I stuff it

POITIER

I understand this situation
But I'm not fully convinced
Let's leave him in there for now

(Henrique and the Marshal leave for now, leaving the three heroes alone.)

ACT 3: SCENE 1

(Marceau and Vespasian stand in front of the deceased Duke's chambers.)

MARCEAU

Oh god, my god
I'm deep in despair
I just don't know what I should do
Tell me, I need your support

VESPASIAN

Bro I still haven't forgiven you for fucking my mom

MARCEAU

This foul language again!
Have you no manners?
And no advice as well, it seems

VESPASIAN

If I help you, will you leave my wife and family alone?

MARCEAU

How right you are!
For when I leave, I'll never see them again
How tragic and depressing
If there was one more night
That I could spend-

VESPASIAN

Just shut up, I'll help you out

MARCEAU

But how should I perform this escape?
What tricks and twists have you prepared?

VESPASIAN

Now listen up
Go to the town gate
And leave
That's all

MARCEAU
Brilliant!

VESPASIAN
Yeah, you too

MARCEAU
Thank you, brother!
If you'll excuse me,
I must flee this place at once
Just vouch for me

VESPASIAN
I'll tell them that you died

MARCEAU
That's a fine excuse
Just know
If you don't want to end up like me
Be wary of Dieudonné

VESPASIAN
I always knew he was no good
But now you should leave

MARCEAU
Indebted I am to you, for always
One day, I will repay you
But before that, I'll prepare

(Marceau leaves.)

VESPASIAN
Finally, he's gone

(Poitier enters the scene. He waves around a paper)

POITIER
Why dost thou lurk here, 'tis so late
And have you seen Marceau?
I've got a letter from your mother,
That's addressed to him

VESPASIAN
For fucks sake
He's dead, alright
His body went up in flames

POITIER

Just like that you say?

VESPASIAN

Yeah that's how it works

POITIER

Each day just gets stranger
More and more good folks we lose
I'll miss the boy,
A strong and handsome man

VESPASIAN

Absolutely

POITIER

I must excuse myself
(hands Vespasian the letter)
My duty calls
To you, have a pleasant night

VESPASIAN

Sure

POITIER

...

I see, you're a simpleton

(The Marshal leaves the scene. Vespasian leaves the opposite way.)

ACT 3: SCENE 2

(In front of the Chateau, at the horse stable. Marceau is on his way out of town. He is stopped by the Duchess.)

DUCHESS

My lover
Tell me, what's the rush?

MARCEAU

Spare me your words made of honey

DUCHESS

Every night I lie awake
Waiting for your touch

MARCEAU
So do I, my dear
But fate is pushing me far out
Our time was lovely
Although short

DUCHESS
Oh my, but we went for hours!

MARCEAU
I meant our days.

DUCHESS
Just tell me, what happened?

MARCEAU
I stabbed him, my friend
He left me no choice

DUCHESS
Who did?

MARCEAU
I mustn't

DUCHESS
Your secrets are well kept with me

MARCEAU
Then listen, my dear
The Duke's death was the second son's doing

DUCHESS
My god-
So Dieudonné's at fault?

MARCEAU
This is all I can say

DUCHESS
Now you're going away
I'm a widow now, can't we be together?

MARCEAU
All my ties are better to be severed
I may love you
But maybe too much
Live a life in the gentry
I'll flee towards Nancy!

DUCHESS

Take me, too!

MARCEAU

Trust me, you staying here's for the better

DUCHESS

I'd rather die

MARCEAU

I can't take another loved one's loss

DUCHESS

So you know how I feel

You leaving me here

It's as if you'll pass away

MARCEAU

A fate worse than death already awaits me

DUCHESS

There's no one to convict you

MARCEAU

I stand as my own judge

DUCHESS

Am I infatuated with a knight or a fool?

MARCEAU

Another man would suit you best

DUCHESS

I already thought that way

When I seeked you instead of my husband

MARCEAU

Then seek once more

DUCHESS

Why won't you love me?

MARCEAU

I don't deserve you

DUCHESS

If punishment is what you seek

Then stay with me and hate yourself for it

MARCEAU

I don't hate you enough to do so
Take care, my only

(Marceau exits, leaving the Duchess behind.)

DUCHESS

First my husband
Now my pet?
What good is a lady that won't be pleased
I deserve a brigade of lovers
I won't sully my hands
Just to make me feel good
Should I seduce dear Eufie?
If she even knows my spots
The young ones are also clumsy
I'll just take the guards
But they don't deserve this honor
Oh, Marceau
You were the most endearing
There was no one else quite like you
I should return to my chambers
As long as my memory's still clear

(The Duchess leaves the scene.)

ACT 3: SCENE 3

(Alexis is stuck in the shutter with Teresa and Jean trying to get him out)

TERESA

(Pulling on the door)
This is a really tough trap
I must admit
It just won't bend or let alone budge
Maybe if I kick the door?
That could be it
What do you think, oh Jean, my Lad?

JEAN

You're right, I'm at a loss
No matter what I twist, pull or toss
Should we get an ax?
Teresa, my dearest,
Through thick and thin
What do you think?

ALEXIS

What about me here?

TERESA

Did you hear a sound, chaton?

JEAN

By no means

ALEXIS

Hilarious, chums

TERESA

Hold on, what have I found?

Goodness!

Behold!

ALEXIS

Don't leave me in the dark!

JEAN

What is it?

TERESA

(smirks)

My giant breasts of course

And also this key on the ground

JEAN

Bit too convenient

What dost thou think?

TERESA

I don't

For I'm a fool

ALEXIS

Alright we get it

JEAN

'xcept maidens

TERESA

That stung

ALEXIS

Just open the door

Put the key in the hole

JEAN
Try that with the maidens, too
Just for a change

TERESA
Enough, my man

(They open the door and Alexis is free again.)

ALEXIS
I'm indebted to you

TERESA
Indeed, you are

JEAN
What's that there?
Oh, a jar?

TERESA
I'll open it

JEAN
But what's inside?

TERESA
This smell?
(yelling from the top of her lungs)
It's Henrique's fart!

(Teresa coughs and falls to her knees. Jean holds her in his arms.)

ALEXIS
My god, you breathed it in!
The gas, oh terrible, this sin!
You look so pale, but please prevail!

JEAN
Those macaroons, they hid themselves within

(Teresa's voice fades)

TERESA
(whispering)
This fiend...

ALEXIS
Please, you must speak up

TERESA

Tell me, if tomorrow was your last day,
What would you do?

ALEXIS

Erect a statue in your name

TERESA

Please, you make it sound like it's the end
And not a happy one at that
I don't wish for a happy ending
For our friendship was enough
The days we spent
Years after years
How could I ever forget
If I could, I would live through it
Until I'm tired of taking breaths
I never married my man
Have no child to call me Mother
But you, Alexis, made me feel
Like you were a brother
Protecting me from any darkness
(*struggles to put her hand to Jean's cheek*)
And you, Jean, were my love
My whole life
And you'll stay as that beyond this existence
If there were words
Stronger than "I love you"
I'd speak them to you until my lips fell off
Now I see a light
Tell me, brothers,
If I step through right now
Will you be alright?

ALEXIS

Don't think of us

JEAN

Of course we will,
just like you, my equal

TERESA

Please look past your tears for now
You still need to fight

ALEXIS

I just don't see a path

TERESA

You don't need to
Look, the moon tonight is beautiful
Afraid my sight is gone,
I can't witness it,
But I still know it is

JEAN

My Sweetheart
Why tell lies?
Aren't you staring up right now?
With your own eyes?
Your soul's still there,
Don't fade away

(But Teresa dies.)

ALEXIS

Farewell,
Just know I promise you
You'll stay a part of me

(Teresa turns into a ghost.)

GHOST TERESA

My brethrens,
Look who's back

(Ghost Timéo appears.)

GHOST TIMÉO

Welcome to the banquet

ALEXIS

No time for grief, I see

JEAN

What now, Alexis
How will we proceed?

ALEXIS

Let's track this goddamned bastard down
I know just the right man to ask

(They leave.)

ACT 4: SCENE 1

(Vespasian is standing in the gardens. Alexis and Jean enter.)

ALEXIS
I've found you, fiend!

VESPASIAN
I never hid

JEAN
You killed our friend?

VESPASIAN
Can't say I did

ALEXIS
Then tell us, who has stained their hands?
Who let the brown escape his pants?

VESPASIAN
Listen, I have nothing to do with this
Just go and find Henrique

ALEXIS
So-

VESPASIAN
Shut up, man

ALEXIS
But-

VESPASIAN
I seriously can't hear it anymore

ALEXIS
I need to speak in rhyme, like poetry

VESPASIAN
Yeah that's what I'm talking about

ALEXIS
Alright, I get it
Fine

VESPASIAN

I'm getting out of here
Have fun getting to Henrique,
It won't be easy
No one there to guard him, though
But he's skilled in combat

(Before Alexis can utter another word, Vespasian leaves.)

ALEXIS

What's up with him?

JEAN

We'll never know

ALEXIS

His words hurt to the core
The content doesn't, not so much,
Way worse, the tact and tone

JEAN

Don't fret, what are you?
A guitar?

ALEXIS

You jest too much, let's go

(The Duchess enters.)

DUCHESS

But not before you listen, son.

ALEXIS

Your grace

DUCHESS

I know who took Timéo's life
You need that answer just as much
Marceau, he fled the realm
But understand, he didn't mean to

ALEXIS

Nonsense
Wasn't he our friend?

DUCHESS

And he still is

ALEXIS
Then why?

DUCHESS
Dieudonné used his power

ALEXIS
That bastard
I will end that tyrant's bloodline

DUCHESS
You would really go that far, son?
He's still family, after all

ALEXIS
So was father

DUCHESS
Can you live with the guilt
Of making me lose another beloved?

ALEXIS
I can't let these clogs continue

DUCHESS
Don't you care about the lives lost?

ALEXIS
Of course, I will repent

(Alexis and Jean leave the Duchess behind.)

ACT 4: SCENE 2

(In front of Henrique's chambers. Alexis and Jean are present.)

ALEXIS
Where is he, the foe?
Come out, hear me shout!
I swear it, you shall fear my wrath!
Finger for finger, I'll tear them all off
Evil and vile, your games shall find an end

(Henrique enters the scene. He is holding a rose in one hand.)

HENRIQUE

Look at this, it's Mister Piss
 Master of the shitter
 Just go on, you noble's son
 You're worth no more than litter
 Is it me that you seek?
 Apologies, you dare come-hither
 The hots for me, you little freak?
 Oh my, oh my, you make me quiver

ALEXIS

You creep me out a bit, no lie
 I'll leave you be, okay? goodbye

HENRIQUE

Not so fast!
 Where darest thou go?
 Think of it this easy, Sire?

JEAN

Let me handle this, 's that fair?

ALEXIS

Not quite, I'm in your care

(Jean approaches Henrique. Henrique puts his hand to his sword hilt.)

HENRIQUE

Very good, a worthy foe
 Say, are you skilled with the sword?

JEAN

I prefer fists, or wits
 Those old-fashioned duels are such a bore

HENRIQUE

(drops his sword.)
 I'll bore you with this

(Henrique strikes, Jean evades)

JEAN

Afraid that's a miss

HENRIQUE

Provoking me, I take it?

JEAN
 You're joking, see, I fake it
 And speaking of jokes, is this fight one as well?

HENRIQUE
 The way that you dance, I can't tell

JEAN
 Then tell me, how does this feel?

(Jean stabs Henrique.)

HENRIQUE
 I'd say it's like a rod made of steel

JEAN
 You're wise, but still do jests
 I'll take my leave now
 And leave you to your final rest

(Jean leaves. Henrique speaks to Alexis.)

HENRIQUE
(suffering)
 Hear my out, alright?
 I farted in the jar
 Just know that it was meant for you
 The only mistake in my master plan
 Was forgetting Teresa, that dark skinned slut

ALEXIS
 Being racist towards my friend, I see
 You're just jealous of her chivalry

HENRIQUE
 Before you go,
 I thought you'd like to know
 The Duke didn't die by your hands
 His heart was still beating
 Until someone came
 'Twas Dieudonné
 Only he is to blame

ALEXIS
 You speak the truth?

HENRIQUE
 Dying men don't hide their wisdom

(Alexis leaves the scene.)

HENRIQUE
 My final words
 They're here, after all
 What should they be?
 I know!
 Listen, abyss:
 Bussy!

(The rooftop of the Chateau de Faubremont. There are two privies, one with and one without walls. Dieudonné is using the open-air version and is about to clog. Jean appears on the roof full of rage. Alexis followed not long after. Dieudonné is visibly upset about this unwelcome visit.)

DIEUDONNÉ
 Begone with you!
 Leave now, shoo
 Can't you see
 I'm taking a poo

ALEXIS
 Lots you must have taken
 Demon of the bowels
 Now answer me
 Did Father fall by your hands?

DIEUDONNÉ
 That fool must have told you
 I'll tell you the truth
 There's no one who will hear you out anyway
 I killed him, our Duke

ALEXIS
 I loathe you
 With all that I have
 But even if I want to strike,
 I just can't
 Mark my words
 You won't die because of me
 Live on, and feel my hate

DIEUDONNÉ
 I don't care
 I will shit again
 Just like you
 We're the same

ALEXIS

We are not equal
I shit with pride
You take your dumps like a coward

DIEUDONNÉ

A coward doesn't shit under the sky like this

ALEXIS

True, a pervert would
Perverted coward

DIEUDONNÉ

The pervert is you,
You struck father first
Isn't that correct?

ALEXIS

He took my darling for a concubine!

DIEUDONNÉ

Is this the lovebird you were referring to?
(opens the privy next to him. Eufemia is inside, gagged and tied.)

EUFEMIA

(cries for help but her mouth is covered by the gag cloth.)

ALEKS

You dare stoop so low?

DIEUDONNÉ

I planned on letting her enjoy
The same fate as Timéo
And frame you for the deed
Who cares!
Henrique the fool
Wasn't up to the task
I'll take the matter into my own hands then
(grabs Eufemia and holds the dagger to her throat)

EUFEMIA

(weeps.)

ALEKS

Why bring her into this?
What did she ever do?

DIEUDONNÉ

Oh, ignorance, how bliss
Just one word: macaroons

ALEKS

So you shat yourself too?

DIEUDONNÉ

I was hungry!
My gut still feels the pain
But more importantly
My desire is to reign
My way to be the duke, my brother
Is only through your demise

ALEKS

We haven't had a chance to talk this through

DIEUDONNÉ

Enough!
After all, it's futile
Framing you for murder
Just doesn't seem to work
I better make you watch instead
How your loved one
Lets death do you part prematurely

ALEKS

You wouldn't
Take my life instead

(Aleks approaches, Dieudonné adjusts his position and cuts Eufemias neck just enough for it to bleed)

DIEUDONNÉ

Watch out, I mean it
You'd really give it up?
For a talentless wench like this
Noble only out of pity
A virgin no more
Robbed by your father
I bet he even sucked her titties
So out of hate
You tried to take his life
So did I
We truly are the same
Not quite
I was successful
And will stay so once more

(Henrique enters the scene, badly wounded.)

HENRIQUE
But there is!

(Henrique runs towards Dieudonné and tackles him. Eufemia escapes Dieudonné's grasp and falls to the ground)

DIEUDONNÉ
(trying to escape Henrique)
What do you think you're doing?

JEAN
You didn't join the dead?

HENRIQUE
My last words,
They made me cringe
So I want another chance
With my last breath
I shall change my fate
And challenge how I lived
I'll take you down, murderer

DIEUDONNÉ
Demonizing your own kind doesn't make you a saint
That's what the devil did

HENRIQUE
Dieudonné!
I swear I'll take you down with me
Into the abyss
My final words, o listen, Macaroons!
I say: I stand above you!

(Henrique pulls Dieudonné and jumps off the roof. They both fall.)

DIEUDONNÉ
Bussy!

(They crash on the ground. Alexis and Jean stare down to see.)

ALEXIS
... I can't believe it

JEAN
How cringe that was?

ALEXIS
Indeed

JEAN
That was so lame

(Alexis and Jean stand victorious.)

EUFEMIA
Oh, Alexis!
I knew you would save me
(falls around Alexis' neck)

JEAN
But Henrique did

ALEXIS
Jean, we're having a moment here

JEAN
I'll leave you two be, then

(The Marshal enters the scene.)

POITIER
What happened here?

ALEXIS
Would you listen?
What we have to say might seem absurd

POITIER
So what

ALEXIS
Dieudonné killed my father,
Teresa fell through Henrique's doing
The poops in the toilet, all was his work
And Marceau was the one who stabbed Timéo

POITIER
Where is he?
That scum!
A criminal he is
And criminals must face justice

ALEXIS
Someone must have helped him flee

JEAN
He can't be that far
There's just not enough Time
There's a chance we can catch up

ALEXIS
Eufemia, please wait for me
At my bed chambers

EUFEMIA
At once!
My legs are getting tired
(leaves.)

POITIER
Stop loitering then!
Forward we go!
There's no Time to lose

(They run. Everyone leaves the scene.)

ACT 4: SCENE 3

(The town's outskirts. Marceau rests under the starry sky. Alexis, Jean and the Marshal enter.)

POITIER
We found him
Tell me, how did you know?

ALEXIS
He and I spent our youth here
As friends, long ago

MARCEAU
I'm glad you remember
Please keep me in your memory
It will be all that's left of me

ALEXIS
You don't mean...

MARCEAU
Oh no, 'Lex, I do
Everything went out of control
I'm a simple man
I never wanted it to end like this
So instead, I'll end it by my own hand
Just once in my life I want to be in control

ALEXIS

But we can still talk-

MARCEAU

Why should we?

Actions are enough

ALEXIS

Will you slit your wrist

MARCEAU

No I prefer poison

ALEXIS

I'll take it from you

MARCEAU

That does sound like you

That's why I ingested it an hour ago

I'm glad you joined me here,

For my final moments

Just promise me:

Don't join me for a while

when I cross to the heavens

ALEXIS

Why?

Why did you kill him?

MARCEAU

Timéo?

I had to, I was just a slave to my peers

But vassals can break free

I destroy the shackles of suppressed fate

By finding my freedom in death

(Marceau coughs blood, he passes out, then ceases to breathe.)

POITIER

He's gone

(The three ghosts of Timéo, Teresa and Marceau enter.)

GHOST TIMÉO

Finally,

I can ascend

My request was granted

You held your word, 'Lex

GHOST TERESA

Is it Time to go?

GHOST MARCEAU

I'm afraid so

GHOST TIMÉO

Don't be afraid, this is a blessing

GHOST MARCEAU

I'm sorry I took your life, comrade

GHOST TIMÉO

Do not worry, I never wanted to keep living

My suicide note was halfway done

GHOST MARCEAU

Splendid

ALEXIS

Farewell, my friends

JEAN

If you allow us,

Can you wait for a good while?

We'll reunite for sure,

But not before we enjoy our lives to the fullest

GHOST TERESA

I wouldn't want it any other way

(The spirits have found rest and Timéo, Teresa and Marceau ascend to heaven)

POITIER

There's just one last thing left,

Duke Alexis,

You reign

As the rightful heir to your pops

ALEXIS

Let's return to the quarters

(Everyone leaves.)

EPILOGUE

(Alexis, Jean and Poitier return home. Alexis searches for Eufemia towards his bed chambers.)

ALEXIS
Eufemia, dear

EUFEMIA
Darling!
Explain what happened these nights?

ALEXIS
Who cares, you're also an accomplice

EUFEMIA
But-

ALEXIS
Silence, dear!

(He slaps her.)

JEAN
Nice one, brother

EUFEMIA
I can't believe I love you!

ALEXIS
I love you as well, then you baked those macaroons
Now, not one more word from you!
You're banished from the kitchen.

EUFEMIA
How rude-

(Alexis slaps her again.)

ALEXIS
Are you as deaf as you are a failure?
I betroth you, so you are no longer a maid
Someone else will now bake in your place
Your only service from now on will be in my bed

(Eufemia is taken away by the guards to her chamber.)

JEAN

Nice work, comrade
This day shall stay a reminder
Toilets shan't stay clogged
A true gentleman with noble heart
Stands up for every poop and shart

ALEXIS

I shall never eat another Macaroon

JEAN

Just one tiny thing
Teresa is gone
So I'm maidenless now
How will I find a new betrothed?

ALEXIS

Let's throw a banquet
With wine, food and concubines
I'll give you as many as you desire, companion

JEAN

You fill me with joy, lust and pride
Are you familiar with that gothic seamstress?
A true beauty to behold
I've had an eye on her for quite some time
Forgive me, Teresa
But bygones are just that
I hope she likes wine

ALEXIS

Let's prepare all at once

(The curtain closes. All actors thank the audience.)

THE END